Personal Statement

Avery Reyna — University of Michigan Information PhD Program

Looking back at my undergraduate years, it was the most intellectually formative time of my life. Coming in as a 17-year-old, bright-eyed with a curious spirit, even after taking heaps of AP classes, there were so many paths I could have traveled down, but I had to be smart about finding out which one was right for me. In pursuit of these interests and aptitudes, I completed at least one internship in a new field each semester, helped teach *Social Power & Inequality*, conducted interdisciplinary research across three domains, and completed two REUs with **Jim Thatcher** and **Brian Smith**. Needless to say, pursuing a PhD was inevitable.

I didn't know research like that was possible for me until a friend described her summer spent applying computational methods to questions in peace science. Being intrigued, I applied to the *Burnett Honors College* for the resources I needed: faculty seeking undergraduate researchers, advanced seminars, and a research-oriented community. The application was competitive—only fifteen admitted—but I was one of them. I treated my undergraduate years as a deliberate experiment, moving from drug policy mapping to online safety research to political violence prediction, testing what drew me to computational methods in social science. What emerged wasn't a domain preference, but fascination with how computational tools could make entirely new questions answerable—the next step: exposure to researchers at these intersections.

As a first-generation, Afro-Latino student, I had never seen a clear path to a research career—there weren't many PhD students, let alone successful researchers, who looked like me. Working with Jim Thatcher and Brian Smith through two REUs changed that. Beyond technical training and meaningful work, they saw a future for me in academia and actively mentored me toward that goal. Watching them work at disciplinary intersections showed me what it looks like to ask questions that don't neatly fit into categories—and to build a career around that curiosity. Having faculty invest in me as a future scholar made the PhD feel like a space where I could belong.

After graduating, I worked as a Software Engineer at Capital One to deepen my developer expertise. It was strategic: the questions I wanted to explore in AI-assisted programming were occurring right in front of me, allowing me to understand these systems from the inside. Yet working in industry clarified something: I missed leading research, pursuing ideas that required sustained investigation, and building prototypes to test half-baked conjectures. That's when "inevitable" became the right word—not because other paths weren't viable, but because research was the only work that felt like mine.

The School of Information offers what I need next: an interdisciplinary department where computational methods, social science, and HCI converge, creating endless opportunities for collaboration and inspiration. The faculty's commitment to developing independent researchers and preparing them to lead their own labs mirrors the mentorship that shaped my path at the doctoral level. My questions about democratizing programming can become a sustained research agenda, and my interdisciplinary, first-generation background can become a strength.